crisis)[23] came into being. Almost immediately, the Burmese Communist Party launched a military campaign designed to overthrow the new government[24] at the same time as some British diplomats were encouraging the largely Christian Karen ethnic group to seize power.[25] All this set in motion a series of wars between the Burmese state and ethnic minorities on its borders; these wars have only recently died away (and still persist in some areas).

For the Rohingyas, independence brought a particular set of problems. They had remained loyal to the British when the Japanese had invaded in 1942. This, in turn, had provoked serious inter-communal strife with the Rakhine[26] and led to the fragmentation of the previously mixed Rohingya and Rakhine communities across Arakan. By the time the Japanese surrendered, most Rohingyas who had lived in the south had fled to the north of the province, and ethnic Rakhine who had previously lived in the north had fled south. Even worse, the British had promised partial independence to the Rohingyas but reneged on this once the war was over.[27] This led to a short-lived revolt[28] by the Rohingyas, and then some Rohingya politicians petitioned for the inclusion of the northern districts of Arakan into what was then East Pakistan.[29]

Compared to the sustained armed revolts of other ethnic groups, these attempts to gain a degree of self-determination were minimal but still led Burma's new, post-independence rulers to see the Rohingyas as hostile.[30] Indeed, unlike most of Burma's many ethnic groups, they were not given full citizenship in 1948.[31] It is hard to understand why the Rohingyas were targeted in this way. They are ethnically different to most other groups in the country, and they are the largest Muslim community. Most likely they were simply a target of convenience, with the ethnic tensions provoked by World War II still very raw. However, Prime Minister U Nu indicated on several occasions that this was a temporary problem and that 'The Rohingya has the equal status of nationality with Kachin, Kayah, Karen, Mon, Rakhine and Shan'.[32] There is ample evidence in the Burmese legal framework[33] and in the practical decisions that were made that the Rohingyas were not seen as being especially different[34] to any other ethnic minority in the period of democratic rule up to 1962.[35] They are described